

The Eternal Soundtrack

A new book reveals the talent, true grit and sheer tenacity that lie behind the legend of Lata Mangeshkar as she turns 80



LATA MANGESHKAR: IN HER OWN VOICE

Conversations with
NASREEN MUNNI
KABIR
Niyogi Books
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| By Kaveree Bamzai |

The problem with legends sometimes is that we take them too seriously. We give them high-faluting names, put them in pretty, neatly labelled boxes and keep them on the national mantelpiece, right up there with the Republic Day honours and titles like the Nightingale of India or the Voice of the Millennium. Which is what makes *Lata Mangeshkar: In Her Own Voice* worth its wrist-bruising weight. It shows the woman beneath the aura, the eternal singing star, the soundtrack to our lives for the past 60 years, playing the slot machines in Las Vegas all-nighters, while sipping on Coca-Cola. The cricket fan gushing over a signed photo of Sir Donald Bradman, which says To Lata. The movie enthusiast, slipping into a Mumbai theatre to watch her favourite Yul Brynner's *The King and I* 15 times. And the excited young girl, buying her first car, a grey Hillman, for Rs 8,000 in the days she used to be paid Rs 200 for a song.

But what makes this book exciting is not just the trivia about Mangeshkar who will turn 80 this year. No. It is, like the woman who speaks through it, ultimately about the music. Of how it was composed, recorded and disseminated. The dust, hot lights and the noise of studio floors where early songs were recorded after the day's shoot was done. The single microphone on which duets had to be sung. The fight she spearheaded with other playback singers for royalties. The "cheap" lyrics she would often refuse to sing.

"When I sing I never wear shoes. My father believed singing was like entering a temple of Goddess Saraswati. Singing is like prayer to me."



The book speaks of an era where music and lyrics meant something more than a marketing tool. Where makeovers mattered less than mastery over the song. And where the established powers did not eat their young, hungrily. In the course of conversations over several months, Nasreen Munni Kabir draws out Mangeshkar on the subject of her music directors, her early difficulties, her supposed rivalry with her sister, even her disappointment, if any, for never marrying. For the first time, we hear Mangeshkar's voice, not in the haunting elegiac tone of *Mahal's* emblematic *Aayega aanewala* or in the playful naughtiness of *Lara lappa lara lappa* from *Ek Thi Ladki*, but as the woman who became the fulcrum for her family when she was in her teens after her father, a well-known theatre producer and actor, passed away. She speaks of the early days when